was able to touch over 1300 locations, 325 of which were in UP alone. 3D was also used to reach out to remote places. ‘We even managed to get to the upper reaches of Uttarakhand. It was a logistical challenge, but we did it,’ says a Team Modi member.

This was quintessential ‘shock and awe’ campaigning, Modi-style. Two studios were set up in Delhi and Gandhinagar for Modi’s ‘outreach’. A crew of 2500 members handling 125 3D projector units were involved and more than 7 million people reportedly witnessed the 3D shows over twelve days. In the 2012 assembly elections, Modi would appear in 3D in an almost static position on a flat screen; this time, the technology team innovated and attempted to capture every movement, including someone serving him a cup of tea, or a towel being asked for to wipe the sweat. ‘We wanted Modi to appear as lifelike as possible to heighten audience excitement,’ is how the 3D adventure was described to me. I later asked Kishore how much they spent on each 3D show. He wouldn’t tell me but BJP sources said it was amongst the most expensive elements of the campaign. ‘Upwards of Rs 200 crore’ is one figure I was given. Whatever the final amount, the purpose had been served. Modi was, literally, everywhere.

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On 8 May, Modi was to conclude his Varanasi campaign with two rallies and then participate in an aarti by the banks of the Ganga. But twenty-four hours before his arrival, the local administration denied him permission—citing security concerns—for a rally in Beniabagh in the heart of the city and for the aarti.

Free from his campaign in Amritsar, senior leader Arun Jaitley was now supervising the final push in Varanasi. Incensed by the administration’s decision, he decided to go on the offensive. A legal defence was prepared, and a letter sent to the Election Commission and the district magistrate’s office. The local BJP was told to stage a dharna in protest. ‘We genuinely felt that the administration was under pressure from the SP government not to allow Modi into the city,’ Jaitley told me later. The fact that the DM,